



◀ Scenes from the Blitz

Men and women alike sheltered in London's subway stations for protection from Nazi bombs. Women were usually responsible for making sure children were safe and entertained. Here, a woman teaches arithmetic to children during an air raid at London's Elephant and Castle station.

allow the creation of three all-female regiments in the Soviet Air Forces. The most celebrated were the “Night Witches”—23 aviators under the command of Yevdokia Bershanskaya—who carried out over 20,000 bombing sorties against the forces of Germany and its allies. Britain and the US also used female pilots but they were not sent into combat. Instead they mainly flew aircraft from factories to military bases. In other countries, women took on auxiliary roles, working as nurses, drivers, and secretaries, to free up male soldiers for

combat. Most British women worked on the Home Front, where one of their most vital tasks was operating anti-aircraft batteries and searchlights.

Operating undercover

Resistance and partisan groups often recruited women because they were not subject to the same suspicions as men, and could sometimes perform covert operations unnoticed. In the French Resistance women regularly acted as couriers but it was rare for them to assume leadership roles or participate in violent operations. An exception was Marie-Madeleine Fourcade, known as “Herisson” (Hedgehog), who led a group of over 3,000 agents. However, in Poland, which

80,000
British women
served in the
Land Army during
World War II.

